Championships, to see the celebrations and join in with the madness at home. I'd love to get my share of all that excitement when we score: bodies flying around through the air and people hugging and kissing each other, in London, in Manchester, in Birmingham, in Newcastle, everywhere. I love it.

Out in Sapporo, I didn't want to have to come off the field. If there was one England player, one England supporter still in the stadium, I wanted to be out there celebrating with them. Eventually I went over to the tunnel to do a television interview and then headed back to the dressing room. I was the last one in. Sven-Goran Eriksson shook my hand. He knew what it meant for the team. The Usher album was blaring out again. Rio was leading the dancing in the middle of the floor, kicking discarded uniform and shin pads out of the way. I wish we could have played Brazil the following day. That same night, even. We felt so strong; everyone was still so hyped up. I'm sure we'd have won. The atmosphere in the dressing room after we'd beaten Argentina made it feel like this England team was invincible.

Back at the hotel, Mum and Dad were waiting for me. They came out to every game in Japan. Mum was in tears—just what I needed to start me off—and I think Dad was having to hold them back as well:

'I'm so proud of you, son.'

Tony Stephens made his way there after the game. He's a soccer fan as well as an agent working in the game, and he'd had a great night along with all the other England supporters inside the Dome. He came up and gave me a hug:

'That was unbelievable, David. Who is it writing your life?'

The room they'd set aside for us was very Japanese: a big, pale grey room with nothing on the walls; large rectangular tables set with white cloths; food and drink laid out for people to help themselves. It wasn't exactly the way you'd set things up for a big party. Tiredness was starting to set in by then anyway, once we'd all shared a bottle or two. Some of the lads headed off to bed early, especially the ones who didn't have family waiting to see them. The rest of us wound down slowly together, toasting England 1 Argentina 0 with a couple of glasses of wine.

It would have been ideal to take the high of beating Argentina on into a knockout game against another major team. Instead, we had to wait nearly a week to play Nigeria in our last group game. A game that, now, we didn't have to win in order to advance. Those five days were long enough for us to